



M. VEDHAN

National championship format needs to evolve, says Dilip Tirkey

Hockey India president Dilip Tirkey, who witnessed the final of the 14th Senior Men's National Championship 2024 at the Mayor Radhakrishnan Hockey Stadium in Chennai, spoke about his federation's vision to restructure the tournament and make it more competitive to safeguard hockey's future in the country.

"The national championship needs to evolve in terms of the format. It has been going on for over 80 years in the same tradition. The one-sided pool matches are not good for the future of Indian hockey. Even the spectators will not attend if there is no competition. We are thinking of revamping the format and introducing a new division for the weaker teams," the former India captain told *Sportstar*.

While all current senior national team players participated in the 2023 senior nationals ahead of the Paris Olympics, only a handful were involved this year. The Hockey India chief explained this decision as a strategy to rest the players after a demanding international schedule, preparing them for the upcoming revamped Hockey India League.

For the record, Odisha hammered two-time champion Haryana 5-1 in the final, while Uttar Pradesh beat Manipur 2-1 to bag the bronze medal.

SAIKAT CHAKRABORTY

INDIAN PLAYGROUND

SPORTOON



1 Aravindh Chithambaram secured the title by defeating Levon Aronian (USA) 2-0 in a blitz tie-break during the second edition of the Chennai Grandmasters Classical Chess Tournament, held at the Anna Centenary Library Auditorium in Chennai. In the final round, it was a three-way tie between Arjun Erigaisi (4.5), Aravindh (4.5), and Aronian (4.5) for the championship. Since Aravindh had the best tie-break in terms of direct encounter, he was given a bye to face the winner of the Arjun-Aronian blitz tie-break (two games). But as that tie-break once again ended in a tie (1-1), Arjun and Aronian played an Armageddon decider. Aronian won by virtue of holding Arjun to a



Aravindh Chithambaram (left) and V. Pranav, with their prizes.

B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

draw with black pieces. V. Pranav drew with Leon Luke Mendonca in the final round to secure the Challengers title.

S. PRASANNA VENKATESAN